



Embracing the future: The Indians may have been latecomers to the T20 party, but they are well and truly the life and soul of it.

India course-corrected by trouncing minnows Afghanistan, Scotland and Namibia, it was too late. India's early exit precipitated Kohli's departure as captain from all formats and prompted calls for more intent from batters in the shortest format.

With the next T20 World Cup looming in less than a year, India's preparations under Rohit Sharma went into overdrive. The Men in Blue played 35 T20Is in 11 months before the next showpiece, the most by any team in that period. India logged the highest run rate (9.32) during this phase, bent on exorcising the ghosts of its timid batting display at the 2021 event.

India docked on Australian shores with belief, bolstered further by Kohli's once-in-a-lifetime masterclass in a tense chase against Pakistan in Melbourne. But similar frailties at the top proved to be the undoing of Rohit's men against South Africa in

the group stage, and eventually against England in the semifinal, when a 169-run target was brushed aside with disdain by the marauding pair of Jos Buttler and Alex Hales.

A dream lay in tatters, but Rohit and Kohli were willing to reinvent themselves in the twilight of their careers for one final shot at the elusive T20 silverware in 2024. Rohit walked the talk on front-loading aggressively in the PowerPlay, smashing match-winning fifties against Australia and England, before Kohli's characteristic grit paid off in the final against the Proteas.

A week after India lifted the trophy in Barbados, the wheels of India's T20 postmodernist era were set in motion on a tour to Zimbabwe, where the phenomenon of Abhishek Sharma offered a glimpse of its potential with a scorching hundred.

The sprightly batch of 2007 and the staid methods of the 2010s have made way for a generation of fearless specialists emboldened by the IPL's Impact Player provision, which has banished the fear of losing one's wicket. It is a team that operates on the principle of maximising scarce

resources as the margins for error constantly shrink — a philosophy that didn't hesitate to drop incumbent vice-captain Shubman Gill ahead of the showpiece. Test and ODI pedigrees are no longer selection guarantees for a side that treats the shortest format as a different sport.

Barring the inimitable Jasprit Bumrah, the wily Kuldeep Yadav and the versatile Hardik Pandya, none of India's other T20I team members are mainstays in the longer formats. Under Suryakumar Yadav's leadership, the conservatism of yore is a distant memory.

That India has married brute force with chilling efficiency since the 2024 World Cup triumph is evident from a scarcely believable track record, which includes 31 wins in 38 matches, with just five defeats. It is a period during which India has breached the 200-run mark 11 times, four more times than the next best team, and nonchalantly brushed aside a 209-run target inside 16 overs.

From an early pioneer to frantically playing catch-up, India is now an avant-garde pacesetter, redefining T20 cricket's rules of engagement.